Master's Thesis Guide
The ESMT MSc Programs

Berlin, October 2025

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1. Introduction

Completion of a Master's Thesis is a requirement for the postgraduate programs leading to the degree "Master of Science (M.Sc.)" of the European School of Management and Technology (ESMT Berlin). The thesis process consists of three stages: 1) choosing a thesis topic and starting a review of key papers in the literature, 2) training in specific research strategies in the field of the thesis topic and preparing a thesis proposal under academic guidance, 3) gathering and processing data and writing the Master's Thesis.

The Master's Thesis develops and tests each student's individual ability to review an area of management studies, to synthesize the main theories and models, and to test these theories empirically. It provides students with an opportunity to apply the research skills and knowledge they acquired in their MSc studies and in prior work experience to a business or management issue that is relevant for their own future career.

The Master's Thesis requires a significant amount of work, as it represents 18 credit points (the culmination of the preparatory session "Introduction to Research Methods" in trimester 5, the "Research Strategy Week", and the time allotted to writing the thesis, both in trimester 6) in the academic curricula of the MSc Programs: Master in Global Management, Master in Innovation and Entrepreneurship and Master in Analytics and Artificial Intelligence. Students are expected to invest approximately 430 work hours in the completion of the thesis. During the Research Strategy Week (RSW) at the beginning of May, students are required to attend a minimum of six sessions (14 contact hours) aimed at guiding them on how to conduct research for their master's thesis. The exact schedule for the RSW is only shared two months prior to the scheduled dates.

This document presents ESMT policies and offers guidance to students, supervisors, evaluators and administrators with regard to the Master's Thesis.

Please address further questions to the MSc program office at MSc-office@esmt.org.

2. The Master's Thesis

As stipulated in the MSc Examination Rules, the Master's Thesis is a requirement for graduating with the ESMT MSc degree. Successful completion of the Master's Thesis shows that the student has qualified for the title of a "Master of Science in Management". The thesis itself is an individual piece of work, meaning that students are graded for it individually, and takes the form of a standard academic paper.

Purpose

The Master's Thesis requires the application of scientific methods and an academically rigorous writing style. More than a declaration of intentions or possible actions, or a description of a situation or of ways of doing things, it is an in-depth analysis and evaluation of a management problem, followed by a set of logical conclusions and recommendations for the implementation of those recommendations.

Process and Deliverables

The Master's Thesis is the outcome of an independent but supervised process of reviewing, questioning, and synthesizing existing knowledge; systematically collecting and analyzing data and information; and making appropriate recommendations. The thesis process follows three stages with different and clearly defined tasks to be accomplished in each stage.

In the first stage, in trimester 5 (Term 4), a list of broad research topics in various fields compiled by ESMT Faculty members is made available to students. Students then have the opportunity to familiarize themselves with a key reading list proposed by ESMT faculty for each topic. The students choose a thesis topic from this list or propose their own topic, provided it is thoroughly justified and is approved by the Faculty Lead.

In the second stage, during the second half of trimester 5 (Term 5), students receive an introduction to the research process and prepare a Master's Thesis proposal under academic supervision. Feedback is provided in an Introduction to Research Methods, where students' research ideas will be presented and discussed and where students receive guidance for determining and refining their thesis topic. After completing the Introduction to Research Methods sessions, students will have a clear concept of their thesis outline and proceed to complete their literature search and start searching for data sources. In May, trimester 6, students extend their skills to conduct research for their Master's Thesis through a series of research methods sessions offered by ESMT faculty as well as scientific writing sessions.

In the third stage, in trimester 6, students gather and process data and write their Master's Thesis. In this trimester, students may seek an internship to gather data and carry out their research with support from practitioners. Alternatively, particularly those who intend to pursue an academic career may opt for working on a thesis topic in close coordination with a professor's own research agenda. Half way through trimester 6, students must submit a first draft containing at least an initial thesis outline, a literature review, research questions, testable hypotheses or propositions, and a description of the empirical methodology. In the second half of the trimester, students will adjust and refine their initial thesis outline, implement their empirical analysis, report results, and write conclusions and recommendations.

Assessment

The Master's Thesis must satisfy several requirements to meet the minimum quality standards expected by ESMT:

1. It is an assignment which can be worked on individually or in a pair.
2. The Master's Thesis is a significant product of academic work. It should be based on 430 working hours.
3. The Master's Thesis is anticipated to be between thirty (30) and sixty (60) pages. The document should include 1.5 line spacing, appendices and references. Supporting appendices and references, however, should not constitute more than 20 percent of the total document. Generally, 60 pages, respectively, constitutes an upper limit to the total thesis length that should be exceeded in exceptional cases only.
4. The deadline for the thesis is taken very seriously. Late submissions will either result in an immediate failure or a penalty to the grade. Extensions can be granted only on grounds of a medical situation or personal calamity. In these circumstances, an extension of two to three weeks to the regular time to complete the Master's Thesis may be granted.
5. The thesis text shall be delivered in the proper format and written in the required citation standards, in line with the thesis template. ESMT provides access to the Chicago Manual of Style in print and online, though the use of any international standard of citation and referencing is acceptable (see §5). The MSc Office will distribute an ESMT Master's Thesis template in MS Word format to ensure proper formatting.
6. The Master's Thesis must be submitted as a single Adobe PDF file via upload to the eLearning platform. The upload criteria will be divulged in advance.
7. **Every thesis will be checked for academic integrity using plagiarism software. Any evidence of plagiarism will be taken very seriously and may lead to failure and potentially dismissal.**
8. The standard ESMT Grading Policy also applies to the Master's Thesis.

ESMT envisions the Master's Thesis as an exercise based on the relevant knowledge, expertise, and skills acquired during MSc coursework. This ensures that the Master's Thesis is the capstone document of the student's studies for the Master of Science (M.Sc.) degree.

Students submit the Master's Thesis by uploading it in Adobe PDF format to the eLearning platform at the end of trimester 6 (see Appendix for deadline). Late submissions will be adequately penalized and result in either immediate failure or point reduction to the final grade.

The thesis examiner, who is an ESMT Faculty member or faculty associated with ESMT, will evaluate the Master's Thesis. A sample grading form can be found in the Appendix. The faculty member will grade on a number of criteria, including:

- Value of the research question (originality, relevance)
- Quality of the literature review (scope, quality of the references, interpretation and synthesis of the literature, theoretical discussion)Quality of the analysis (logical reasoning, data processing)

- Quality of the research methodology (consistency with research question, effectiveness in testing hypothesized effects or informing the proposed relations)

- Effectiveness of written communication (clarity, style, and comprehensiveness)
- Quality of reporting and analysis of results (data processing, clarity of tables and figures, logical reasoning)
- Quality of the conclusion (innovation, applicability)
- Effectiveness of written communication (clarity, style, correct grammar)
- Compliance with formal requirements (correct and consistent citation)
- Performance during the defense (if requested)

After the defense (if requested), the examiners proceed with grading the Master's Thesis. The following is an explanation of how this is done in practice:

1. Examiners submit their proposed grade for the Master's Thesis.
2. All thesis examiners attend a reconciliation meeting, to ensure overall grading consistency within the class. Final grades are determined only after this meeting.
3. The Admissions and Examinations Committee meet to confirm all grades and all final GPAs, giving the go-ahead for graduation.
4. The Master's Thesis grades are communicated to the students as soon as possible, after the Admissions and Examinations Committee meets.

The assessment of the thesis will result in one of three possible outcomes:

1. The student passes with no or very minor revisions required.
2. The student passes with minor revisions required (in case the thesis is selected for the Learning Center, see below); the thesis needs improvement, for instance the correction of grammatical or formatting errors.
3. The student fails, and a major re-submit is needed, with a new assignment or major revisions. A new formal assessment and new grade will follow.

A selection among the top theses will be accessible in the ESMT Learning Center or eLearning Platform once any minor revisions required are completed. All other theses will be archived internally at ESMT for accreditation purposes and will no longer be accessible.

What happens if I fail?

As stated in the MSc Exam Rules, § 7(5), if the Master's Thesis receives a "Fail" grade, the student is either given the chance to rewrite it with adequate improvements, or to write a completely new assignment which reflects the appropriate standard of a Master's Thesis. The MSc Faculty Leads sets the deadline by which the improved or newly assigned work must be submitted. If this improved or new assignment fails to obtain a passing grade of at least 50 percent, the student has

unquestionably failed her/his examinations and will not be awarded the degree, regardless of the average grade of the results obtained in the examinations up to that point.

Cases of failure are rare. They are assessed on a case-by-case basis by the ESMT Faculty and the Admissions and Examinations Committee.

Intellectual property rights, confidentiality, and publication

The Master's Thesis is a major piece of intellectual work that must be original, i.e. not copied in its entirety or in parts from any document, published or unpublished, without due acknowledgement of the source by quoting, citing, and referencing (see Appendix on Ethics and Plagiarism). Please note that Master's Theses may be checked for originality using various means and technology that the Faculty has at their disposal.

ESMT does not publish Master's Theses, nor share them with third parties. If however, the thesis is among the best theses in the class, the thesis should be available to future students as a hard copy in the ESMT Information Center or accessible to students on the eLearning Platform. The MSc Office will ask for the author's (student's) consent, before the thesis is sent to the Information Center. It is the responsibility of the author (the student) to specify if the Master's Thesis contains confidential data and thus must not be published. It is also the student's responsibility to check confidentiality issues with a third party (e.g. the company where the data derives from) and to inform the MSc Office about such issues before giving their consent.

Note, however, that a Master's Thesis is an academic piece of writing that is meant to advance the publicly available body of knowledge in a certain field. Thesis authors should first consult with their advisers about data disguise techniques and other ways of handling confidential information that are commonly accepted in academia so as to avoid the need for confidential treatment of the final document. No topic and/or methodology for a thesis assignment should be finalized unless the thesis can adhere to the aforementioned stipulations.

Students hold the copyright to the content of their Master's Theses, meaning all material that they produced themselves.

ESMT holds the copyright to any version of students' work that is printed or otherwise appears as an ESMT Master's Thesis, meaning that it is in some way characterized as affiliated with ESMT. Examples of such work could, for instance, contain the ESMT logo and/or text designating it as an ESMT assignment, project, or thesis. This applies to all work produced by students as part of their studies at ESMT.

Students who wish to publish or make public the content of their Master's Thesis may only do so under the following conditions:

1. The student takes sole responsibility for publishing, making a work public, and/or contracting with a publisher; and
2. The student ensures that the publication is in no way presented as affiliated with ESMT. The publication may not contain text or design elements such as logos that designate it as an ESMT Master's Thesis that has been evaluated and/or validated by the school.

Those who have questions about copyright and publication or who wish to publish or make public their ESMT Master's Thesis, including all text and other material defining it as such, should contact the MSc program office at MSc-office@esmt.org or the Information Center at infocenter@esmt.org.

3. Deliverables

3.1 First Deliverable: The Thesis Proposal

What is it about?

- Writing a thesis proposal helps you to organize your ideas.
- To be presented in a research forum, towards the end of trimester 5
- The content of the research proposal should tell the reader:
  1. What you want to do (your **research question**)
  2. Why you want to do it (based on **the background** literature and detailing a gap in the research that you would like to fill)
  3. What you are trying to achieve (your **research objectives** and **hypotheses** you want to test or **proposition** you would like to develop)
  4. How you plan to achieve it (your **methodology**)
- Your task is to convince the reader that the proposed research is worth pursuing and achievable within the given time frame and using available resources.
- It can be thought of as a contract between you and the reader, in this case the faculty in charge of evaluating and accepting/rejecting your proposal.
- Acceptance means that your proposal is satisfactory: it has an appropriate destination and an appropriate journey plan. Acceptance does not mean that subsequent success is guaranteed.

The Content of the Thesis Proposal

The proposal should contain six clearly defined components in one page:

1. Title
2. Research Question
3. Background/Motivation (Max 400 words)
4. Hypotheses/Research propositions
5. Research Objectives
6. Methodology (Max 250 words)
7. APPENDIX (in a second page) including timeline, resources and references

<u>1. Title</u>

- A first attempt. Work in progress. It should reflect the current content of the proposal.

<u>2. Research Question</u>

- What is the precise focus of your research? The risk here is lacking focus and attempting to answer too many questions, so keep your description concise.
- It should be carefully motivated by the relevant literature in the background section.

<u>3. Background (max 400 words)</u>

- One of the most important parts of the proposal. It should tell the reader why your research question is important and how motivated you are to pursue this project, based on what you perceive as a contribution you can make to the body of research on your topic.
- Here you demonstrate your knowledge of the relevant literature, so you should include important works regardless of the date of publication as well as up-to-date literature.

• It should clarify to the reader where your proposal fits into the debate, as shows the literature you choose to support your proposal.

• You are expected to show a clear link between your proposal and previous work in your field.

4. Hypotheses/Propositions

• Here you state your preliminary answer(s) to your research question, which you are going to challenge in the remaining of the thesis. A hypothesis could arise from some theory in the background section, or from intuition and priors (this is a *deductive approach*, common in quantitative research). A proposition could be based on observations, or for instance as gained through interviews, survey, case studies, etc. (this is an *inductive approach*, common in qualitative research)

5. Research Objectives

• Precise written objectives leading to observable outcomes (not just general statements of intent)

6. Methodology

• How you plan to achieve your research objectives (i.e. sketch your "Research Design")

► Where you intend to conduct your research (a single organization, an industry, a sector of the economy, etc.)

► Identity of your research population (managers, investors, households, labor union officials, etc.)

• Justify your choice of method in the light of those objectives (i.e. sketch your "Data Collection")

► How specifically the data are to be collected (questionnaires, interviews, analysis of secondary data, or a combination of data collection techniques)

► How you plan to distribute the questionnaires, or how many interviews you plan to conduct and the duration, etc.

► How you are going to adhere to relevant ethical guidelines

► At this point it is not necessary to provide the precise details of the method.

For a detailed guide on research terms and academic expectations, please consult the Information Center's Primer on research terms: https://esmtorg.sharepoint.com/sites/info-center/SitePages/Primer-on-research-basics.aspx

Theses from previous years (both qualitative and quantitative) are available for reference in the Information Center or your eLearning Platform.

How the Thesis Proposal will be evaluated

A. Are your ideas organized into a coherent statement of your research intent?

B. Do the components of the proposal fit together?

► Are the research question and research objectives well motivated by reference to relevant literature? (The research question and research objectives should flow directly from the background section, which should include relevant theory papers in the area).

► Does the proposed methodology flow directly from the research questions and objectives?

C. Viability of the proposal

► Your ideas might be organized in a coherent way and your research plan might look exciting, but is your plan feasible?

► Can this research proposal be carried out satisfactorily within the timeframe and with available resources?

Attributes of a Good Thesis Topic

Capability: is it feasible?

- ► Is the topic something by which you are really fascinated?
- ► Is the research topic achievable within the available time?
- ► Is the research topic achievable within the financial resources that are likely to be available?
- ► Are you reasonably certain of being able to gain access to data you are likely to require for this topic?

Appropriateness: is it worthwhile?

- ► Does your research topic contain issues that have a clear link to theory?
- ► Are you able to state your research questions and objectives clearly?
- ► Will your proposed topic provide fresh insights into the field?
- ► Are the findings for this research topic likely to be symmetrical, that is, of similar value whatever the outcome?
- ► Does your research topic match your career goals?

3.2 Second Deliverable: The Thesis Draft

Content of the Draft

No less than 15 pages of *meaningful* content:

- ► a pretty-much-complete literature overview,
- ► a research question clearly justified and positioned in the literature,
- ► a set of hypotheses and a thorough description of your empirical framework (that is, how you plan to test your hypotheses), or a thorough description of your observations and how they lead to your proposition.

How the Draft will be evaluated

- Extent and scope of the literature review and quality of references:
  - Does the literature overview appear to be comprehensive enough in terms of scope? Are the relevant strands of the literature covered extensively enough? Does the literature overview contain key references from relevant journals?
- Ability to interpret and synthesize the literature and derive a conceptual framework.:
  - Is the student able to reconcile competing theories, contradictory findings, and different research traditions?
- Relevance and originality of the research question and research objectives:
  - Does the research question have a clear link to theory or a conceptual framework? Does this conceptual framework emerge from the literature review?
- Clarity of hypotheses or propositions:
  - In quantitative research: do the hypotheses state with clarity the relations or causal effects that are going to be tested?
  - In qualitative research: do the propositions/conceptual arguments clearly state relations between concepts that will inform the data collection for explanatory or exploratory purposes?

- Research strategy:
  - In quantitative research: Will the proposed empirical methodology (including data collection) be able to identify the hypothesized relations or causal effects?
  - In qualitative research: Is the student able to present a research design, including choice of method (e.g. case studies, action research, etc.), and justify this choice? Were possible alternatives that might also have been used presented and the reasons for the ultimate choice plausible? Is the student explicit as to the data to collect and how it is going to be collected?
- Effectiveness of written communication:
  - Style, clarity, completeness, grammar, etc.

► The examiner will seek to determine whether you are on schedule for completing the Master's Thesis.

3.3 Third Deliverable: The Final Thesis- Structure and Format

The author can choose to structure the document the best possible way to present the analysis and the results. Nevertheless, there are requirements regarding the main sections and the document's formatting, most of which can be resolved by using the Master's Thesis template.

The MSc Office will provide a Master's Thesis template; its use is strongly recommended, especially regarding the title page, which should be uniform for all students.

Please note that the ESMT logo should appear *only* on the title page, and should reflect the formatting found in the template: four centimeters wide, placed one centimeter below the top of the page and one centimeter to the left of the page's right edge.

Structure

Title page

- The full title of your thesis (Calibri font, size 32)
- Please choose a concise title for your thesis. It should be based on your research question, however in most cases the research question is too long for use in the title. For instance:
  - Too long: Can Investors Use a Robo-Advisor to Avoid Behavioral Issues Most Commonly Degrading the Average Investor's Portfolio Returns?
  - Choose instead: Robo-advisors and Investor Behavior- Can Behavioral Traps Be Avoided?
- Your full legal name (Calibri font, size 14, regular font, not bold
- This text: "A thesis submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Master of Science (M.Sc.) at the European School of Management and Technology, Berlin, [year]" (Calibri font, size 10)
- The visual appearance of the title page should be that found in the thesis template provided by the MSc Office

Acknowledgements

- You may want to acknowledge support for your work that you have received from various people and organizations.

Table of contents

- Table of contents including, in no more than three-level detail, section titles numbered in hierarchical order (1., 1.1., 1.1.1.), and providing page numbers for first page of sections

- The text in the table of contents should be Calibri font, size 11.

List of tables and list of figures
- Tables and figures should be numbered and captioned in the document. Unless there are only a few of them, a list of tables and a list of figures should be placed at the beginning of the document, and should include numbers, captions, and page numbers.

Abstract
- Maximum two pages (1.5 spacing), outlining the purpose of the work, the main issues investigated, the methodology used, and its main results and conclusions.

Main body of the thesis
- Introduction
- Chapters
- Conclusion

Figures/Graphs/Charts
- Figures, graphs, and tables may be in the body of the paper. Page breaks (insert/break/page break) can be used to ensure proper formatting.
- Figures and graphs should always be as wide as the margins as long as they remain legible. If margins are too wide for the figure/graph and it becomes blurry when sized to fill the page, then it should be centered. The functions "copy" and "paste special" should be used to ensure a good quality.
- If the figure/graph begins a page, there is no spacing before its title so that the text naming the figure/graph starts at the top of the page. If the figure/graph follows a paragraph, there is spacing of 12 pt before the title. Spacing after the title is 3 pt in both cases.
- Please do not copy-paste figures and charts from internet sources. Create your own figures and charts if and when necessary.
- Between two tables, figures, charts, or exhibits should at least one blank 12 pt line.

Hyperlinks
- Hyperlinks can remain in the text.

List of references
- All references must be listed in alphabetical order by the last name of the first author and include full bibliographic details.
- We recommend using the Chicago Manual of Style as a guide to formatting your citations and reference list. You will find the Chicago Manual of Style in the Information Center online here: https://www.chicagomanualofstyle.org.proxy.esmt.org/home.html.
- Using a different standard style, for instance that of the American Psychological Association (APA) or Modern Language Association (MLA), is acceptable as long as it is applied consistently and correctly throughout the thesis.

Appendices (as applicable), which could include such documents as:
- A sample protocol for interviews (i.e., the template you used, not individual transcripts)
- Survey instrument
- Detailed calculations
- Additional tables and figures
- Copy of raw-data used
- Script/Code underlying the statistical analysis

➔ These and further requirements to be discussed with the thesis mentor

Format

- Page and paragraph settings: A4 paper with 2.5 centimeter margins on each side, 1.5 line spacing. Footnotes, references, tables and figures, and appendices should be single-spaced. Paragraphs should be separated with one blank line.
- Title font: use Calibri font, bold, for all titles and sub-titles. The section titles in your thesis should be font size 16 for level 1 titles, size 14 for level 2 titles, and size 12 for level 3 titles.
- Text font: use Calibri for the body text, headers, footers, page numbers, footnotes, tables, and other regular text. Body text should be in font size 11; footnotes and figure labels should be in size 10.
- Pagination: the document is to be numbered consecutively, starting from the title page.
- Printing: if required or requested by a thesis evaluator, print or photocopy one-sided, consistently clear and dark, using a single staple on the upper left corner.

Appendix 1: Dates and Deadlines

Who?	What?	When? (Deadlines)
MSc Office	Catalogue of thesis topics made available	Oct-Nov 2025
Students	Deadline for submitting own thesis proposal	Nov 19, 2025
Students	Deadline for choosing a topic	Dec 1, 2025
MSc Office	Announcement of final allocation of thesis topics	Dec 19, 2025
Students & Professors	General introduction to research strategies with David Ronayne and tutorial from Guillermo Baquero about thesis proposal	Between Jan 5 & Jan 16, 2026
Students & Professors	Initial lunch meeting with thesis adviser	Between Jan 12 & Jan 23, 2026
Students	Attend select **Research Strategy Sessions** to prepare them for their thesis proposal	Between Jan 19 & Feb 20, 2026
Students & Professors	Second lunch meeting with thesis adviser	Between Feb 23 & 27, 2026
Students	Submit **thesis proposal, uploaded on the eLearning platform**	**Mar 18, 2026 9AM**
Students & Professors	**Research Forum Sessions:** Students present their thesis proposal in no more than 10 min Examiners provide feedback/approval of thesis proposal	**Between Mar 23 & 27, 2026**
Students	Submit **revised thesis proposal**, if initial proposal is not approved	**By April 24, 2026 9 AM**
Students & Professors	Third lunch meeting with thesis adviser	Between May 4 and 15, 2026
Students	**Submit thesis drafts**, uploaded on the eLearning platform, for interim assessment as needed	**June 1, 2026 9AM**
Professors	Professors deliver the evaluation form and written feedback on thesis draft	Jun 15, 2026
Students	**Submit Master's Thesis, final draft, uploaded on the eLearning platform**	**Jul 29, 2026 9 AM**
Students & Professors	Thesis defenses (mandatory for thesis pairs)**	Between Jul 30 and Aug 12, 2026
Professors	Professors submit grades to the MSc Office	Aug 12, 2026
MSc Office	Students receive their final grade	Week of Aug 24, 2026

May be subject to change

*** It is the responsibility of each thesis student group to initiate their supervisor meetings by sending a proposed time and/or any potential questions they may have in advance.**

**** Thesis defenses will be held in an online format between each individual paired-thesis student and their supervisor. Intended duration is 15 minutes, though may last longer. This is a pro-form requirement so that a supervisor may distinguish each student's contribution towards the joint project.**

Appendix 2: Ethics and plagiarism

The following is adapted from Danny Brash's "Master's Thesis Information," Version 3, September 7, 2005, with contributions from Fredrick Björck, Nikos Dimitrakas, Harald Kjellin, Sven Olofsson, Tobias Wrigstad. Permission for reproduction is granted for academic purposes.

Research ethics and misconduct

Conducting research entails agreeing upon certain ethical principles, departmental regulations, and national and international laws. By writing your thesis, you agree not to engage in research misconduct as defined below. Any infringements will lead to disciplinary action. Serious research misconduct is defined by the following criteria:

- Conduct that is deemed by the school to cause damage to the school's standing and reputation in the academic community and/or the public in general
- Conduct that is harmful to others
- Conduct that displays a persistent, flagrant and willful disregard of the rules and guidelines laid down for conducting research within ESMT

The following is a specific list of types of misconduct:

- Fabrication of data in claiming results where none have been obtained
- Falsification of data by changing the collected data to fit your purpose
- Plagiarism - copying the text and/or ideas of others without appropriate and proper bibliographic citation and referencing, therefore implying that you have written the text or devised the ideas yourself when you have not
- Involving people as your research subjects without their knowledge or without safeguarding their right to privacy. You can use the GDPR-compliant privacy form available under the "Resources" tab on your Moodle page when conducting your interviews or consult this tutorial on how to create GDPR-compliant privacy policy statements in your surveys or forms.
- Other practices that deviate from those commonly accepted within the relevant research community for proposing, conducting or reporting research
- Beyond these points, any activity that is illegal based on local, national or international law will result in immediate disciplinary action and will be reported to the relevant authorities

Plagiarism

Probably the most common type of research misconduct is that of plagiarism, which is using material created by someone else without crediting your source. Such material is often text when you are writing a thesis, though it can also be graphs, data, tables, etc.

The two types of plagiarism are:

1. plagiarism of a direct quote – this is when you use the exact text, graphic element, or other material without placing a citation in the body of your thesis, using page numbers when available, and the full bibliographic information for its source in your reference list.

2. paraphrasing plagiarism – this is when you put the ideas of other people into your own words or create your own graph with their data, for example, but neglect to place a citation in the body of your thesis and the full bibliographic information for its source in your reference list.

To avoid plagiarism:

- When you use the exact text as written by others, place it in quotation marks, add a citation in the body of your thesis and use page numbers when available, and add the source to your reference list.

- When you use a table, chart, or other graphic element created by someone else, add a citation under that element and use page numbers when available, and add the source to your reference list.

- When you put the ideas of others into your own words or create a table, graph, chart, etc. using someone else's data, add a citation following the text or graphic element and add the source to your reference list.

In a Master's Thesis, both quotes and paraphrasing the ideas of others will most often appear in the literature review. You should only do this for a few sentences per idea, as your goal is to briefly review the existent literature in a way that leads smoothly into your own ideas.

Some practical tips:

- In the literature review, the goal is to review the existent literature in a way that leads smoothly into your own ideas, so you will generally want to keep quotes and paraphrasing brief.

- Choose using your own words to review the literature above quotes most of the time.
- Use quotes only when the text you need is so uniquely and powerfully important to your own work that it should be left as is.

For a detailed guide on citations, references, and writing good literature reviews, please consult the Information Center's Primer on plagiarism: https://esmtorg.sharepoint.com/sites/info-center/SitePages/Primer-on-plagiarism.aspx.

Honest errors

Misconduct does not include honest errors or honest differences in opinion arising out of data interpretation. In case of doubt, you should discuss the matter with your supervisor.

Appendix 3: Style Guide

The Master's Thesis shall be in English and follow US English grammar, spelling conventions, and bibliographic rules.

Students will have access to the Chicago Manual of Style. This source provides guidelines for all questions of formatting, English writing style, and citing and referencing literature.

For further questions, students can ask their thesis supervisors or the MSc Office.

All students have full access to the Chicago Manual of Style via the Information Center online at https://www.chicagomanualofstyle.org.proxy.esmt.org/home.html.

When using software to create citations and a reference list, it is recommended that students choose the formatting style Chicago Manual of Style, 16th edition, author-date. Using another style, for instance American Psychological Association or Harvard author-date, is acceptable as long as usage is consistent and correct throughout the thesis

Appendix 4: Thesis Feedback Form

Student's name:	
Thesis title:	
Thesis examiner:	
Assessment date:	

CRITERIA	COMMENTS AND ASSESSMENT
Research question's value (originality, relevance)	
Quality of the literature review (scope, quality of the references, interpretation and synthesis of the literature, theoretical discussion)	
Quality of the research methodology (consistency with research question, effectiveness in testing hypothesized effects or informing the proposed relations)	
Quality of reporting and analysis of results (data processing, clarity of tables and figures, logical reasoning)	
Quality of the conclusion (innovation, applicability)	
Effectiveness of written communication (clarity, style, correct grammar)	
Compliance with formal requirements	
Feedback on oral defense (if applicable)	

MASTER'S THESIS GRADE:

Appendix 5: Thesis Support and Specialized Resources

Academic Writing

- Zinsser, William (2006). *On Writing Well*. 30th Anniversary Edition. Harper Collins Publishers.
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Writing a thesis

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- Buy, Y.N. (2009). *How to write a master's thesis.* Los Angeles: Sage.
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Reference style

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Methodology and statistical analysis

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- Clark-Carter, D. (2010). *Quantitative psychological research: The complete student's companion*. 3rd ed. New York: Psychology Press.
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